Q+A

Desi Diva

Restaurateur RITU DALMIA is basking in domestic bliss after her recent marriage to long-term partner Michaela Tedsen



Q. What's the secret sauce to your success?
I don't think there is any secret where I am concerned. Just as we got recognition, we also have had several setbacks. The only thing that has made us reach where we are is by accepting that I will make mistakes, and each one has to be a learning not to be repeated again.

Q. What have been the challenges of introducing Indian cuisine to the Italians and vice versa?
Introducing Italian to the Indian palate was a lot harder than introducing Indian to the Italians. But it's also about being at the right place at the right time. When I opened my first Italian restaurant in India, it was way before its time. When we opened Cittamani in Milan in 2017, it was really the first 'proper' Indian restaurant... not serving chicken balti or vindaloo. Milan embraced Cittamani with open arms.

Q. A little over two months since your marriage. How does it feel to be Mrs & Mrs?
Honestly, it feels fabulous. I did not think it would change anything, but how wrong I was. It does change the dynamics. There is a lot more security and it almost feels like a solid, sturdy house instead of a glam camp. I have become more sensitive about how much I travel and am finally trying to find a better work-life balance because now there's two of us.

Q. You're a leading light and champion of LGBTQIA+ rights. What positive changes do you see manifesting in this sphere in 2025 and beyond?
2023 and 2024 were bad years. The petition for civil rights was quashed and I'm not sure when it will be admitted again. However, a lot of young people have been fighting for their right not to get married to a person of the opposite sex under pressure from parents. We still have a long way ahead, but hope and patience are something one cannot give up.

Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH

-with Priya Pathiyan